Frames, Relation, and the Empty Limit

A Metaphysical Companion to Graphic Equalisation

Matthew Parslow
Independent Researcher

Draft — draft-2026-08-29.6
29 August 2026 • document revision 3

DRAFT — draft-2026-08-29.6 r3 (29 August 2026). This document is under active revision and is circulated for comment, not as a finished result. It is the metaphysical companion to *The Law of Graphic Equalisation* (Theory), and separated from it deliberately: the material here is more speculative than that paper's, and was cut from its conclusion rather than allowed to borrow that paper's standing.

Abstract

Two questions are taken up that the theory paper raises and should not answer. First, whether a well-formed frame approaches a view from nowhere, and in what sense the limit exists. Second, whether relations are prior to relata, and what the substrate can say about a question of that shape. The answers offered are deflationary in both cases and neither is claimed as new: the limit of well-formedness is a purpose-relative optimum rather than a perspectiveless standpoint, and the priority question is underdetermined by this substrate rather than settled or meaningless. What the account contributes is a mechanism for a gradient that has usually been described without one.

1 Scope

This paper depends on *The Law of Graphic Equalisation* (Theory) for its vocabulary, and particularly on that paper's definition of a frame as an instantiated boundary relation, its definition of well-formedness, and its single prohibition with the formal analogue attached to it. Nothing here is used by that paper; the dependency runs one way. The material was written as part of that paper's conclusion and moved here because a conclusion is not where speculative metaphysics should acquire the standing of the work it concludes.

2 Objectivity as a direction

What makes a frame a *somewhere* rather than an *anywhere* is its unnecessary structure: what it holds that does no work, the purposes encoded in it that it does not serve, the distinctions not earning their cost. Well-formedness is defined by the removal of exactly that, so a better-formed frame is a less particular one, and frames doing the same work grow more alike as each is better formed. Objectivity on this reading is a direction rather than a standpoint, and the direction is real and traversable, which is why enquiry makes progress that feels like approaching something.

It is tempting to call the limit of that direction a view from nowhere, and an earlier draft of the theory paper's conclusion did. The temptation should be resisted, and the reason is internal rather than modest. Well-formedness is relative to *what work* a frame is doing, and work is a purpose, and a purpose is a somewhere. Convergence under better-formedness is therefore

convergence toward a *shared* somewhere — the optimum for that work — and not toward a perspectiveless standpoint. Two frames doing the same work converge on each other. Two frames doing different work do not, and nothing in the mechanism suggests they should.

Three further obstacles stand between the direction and any terminus, and they are independent. No level is self-transparent, so even a perfectly well-formed frame cannot observe its own running. A frame's measurement of its own throughput returns its own unit whatever the underlying rate. And the last of the particularity cannot be stripped without removing the criterion of well-formedness along with it, since that criterion is the work: strip the purpose and there is no ranking left, hence no cut, hence no frame.

Remark 2.1 (The limit point is empty). The set of frames with no particularity has no members, and the only object answering to the description — nothing held, no work done, no purpose, hence no cut — is the empty set, which is not a frame and does nothing. Approaching the limit is genuine progress; arriving would be dissolution rather than arrival.

Two things that remark does not license. It is not a claim that objectivity is unavailable or that enquiry is futile, since the direction is real and the convergence is measurable. And it is not an appeal to the uncomputability of a shortest description, which would not support it: minimal descriptions are not unique, description length is machine-relative up to a constant, and the convergence claimed here is relative to what supplies a frame's primitives, for the same reason everything else in this account is.

Remark 2.2 (Relation to prior positions). Neither the graded reading of objectivity nor the suspicion of its limit is new here, and the nearest sources should be described accurately rather than enlisted. Nagel (1986) holds objectivity to be achieved by degrees of stepping back, which is the graded half; but his limit is *contentful* and his residual is a completeness residual — the objective conception omits the subjective, which is real — so he is not a predecessor of the claim that the limit is empty, and is more often read as its target. The absolute conception, a limiting notion maximally free of perspective, is proposed by Williams (1978), whose own reservations concern grounding ethics in it rather than its coherence; the suspicion that no such conception is available belongs to his critics rather than to him. What is offered here is neither position but a mechanism for the gradient both describe: the cost of what a frame holds that does no work.

3 Relations and relata

To exist, in this substrate, is to stand in a relation: what survives every attempted removal in the theory paper is that rules run and a relation across which they run. Particularity is relation — to be cut out is to be related to what one is cut from — so the imperfection of §2 is not a defect accompanying existence but the relation constituting it.

The priority question follows immediately and should not be answered. Are relations prior to relata, or relata to relations?

Remark 3.1 (Underdetermined by this substrate). To determine priority one needs a description of one side independent of the other. Within this account there is none, because a relatum's individuation is the drawing of a boundary and the boundary is the relation. But that is a fact about *this* substrate's resources and not a demonstration that the question has no answer: the relata-first theorist denies precisely the premise the argument runs on, so the argument presupposes one horn and cannot settle between them. The honest statement is that the question is *underdetermined by this substrate*, not that it is unknowable *simpliciter*. An earlier draft claimed the stronger form; it does not survive the observation that its premise is the position it purports to leave open.

What can be said beyond the underdetermination is what the theory paper says of any such choice. Relation-first is the better-formed hypothesis here: it requires no posit this account does not already use, where relata-first requires a grounding claim that does no work in it.

Better-formedness licenses assuming it and does not make it true, which is the same form of answer the physics companion gives to the choice of a synchronisation convention — and the recurrence of that form across a physical and a metaphysical question is the most interesting thing in this paper.

Remark 3.2 (Relation to prior positions). The field does not leave this open, and saying so is more useful than borrowing its authority. Ladyman and Ross (2007) argue the strong form directly — relations as more fundamental than objects, relata as abstractions from them — so they are a proponent of one horn and not a witness for neutrality; the moderate position that relata and relations are inseparable without either being prior is Esfeld (2004)'s. The denial that anything possesses intrinsic, self-establishing existence is far older (Nāgārjuna, 1995), with the qualification that Madhyamaka declines the positive thesis as well, so it is an ally for the negative half of this section and not for the positive one; and the antecedent doctrine of dependent origination predates its systematic form by several centuries.

Remark 3.3 (What the Yoneda lemma does and does not supply). It is tempting to enlist a mathematical statement here, and the temptation should be qualified rather than indulged. The Yoneda lemma, and more precisely the corollary that the Yoneda embedding is full and faithful, gives that an object of a locally small category is determined up to isomorphism by the *functor* of morphisms into it, with the isomorphism natural (Mac Lane, 1971, §III.2). Three things follow for the use made of it. Naturality is not decoration: bare bijections between hom-sets do not determine the object, so the loose gloss "an object is its relations" is strictly weaker than the lemma and false as stated. Morphisms are directed and composable and a category is not a relational structure, so "relation" is not a faithful translation. And the result is internal to a fixed ambient category, with the object given in advance — it is not a metaphysical thesis about what there is. What it does supply is a precise sense in which relational data suffices to individuate within a settled context, which is suggestive of the position of this section and is not an argument for it.

4 A worked instance

The familiar case is worth taking up, both because it locates the material and because the standard resolution is stronger than the one an earlier draft of the theory paper offered.

Asked which came first, the chicken or the egg, the temporal question has an answer and vagueness does not block it. Under every admissible sharpening of "chicken", the genetic novelty is in the zygote, so the first organism satisfying the sharpening developed inside an egg laid by a bird that did not. The answer is invariant under precisification, which is exactly the case in which vagueness is harmless, and it does not require a sharp boundary to exist. The earlier claim that the question presupposes such a boundary was wrong.

Where the puzzle's force actually lives is an ambiguity in *egg* rather than in *chicken*: an egg laid by a chicken and an egg containing a chicken are different objects, and the two readings give opposite answers. That is a disambiguation and not a discovery about carving.

What the substrate contributes is confined to the second question the puzzle can be asked as: whether the kind is prior to its instances, or the instances to the kind. That is §3's question and is underdetermined for the reason given there. The diagnosis worth keeping is of the puzzle's *feel* rather than of its content — pressed on the temporal reading one retreats to the constitutive, and pressed on the constitutive one retreats to the temporal, so an answer seems always to be available somewhere other than where one is standing.

5 Falsifiability

This paper's claims are weaker than the theory paper's and its commitments are correspondingly narrower.

1. **Convergence is purpose-relative.** Fails if frames doing demonstrably different work converge on the same structure as each becomes better formed, which would indicate a purpose-independent optimum and restore the terminus this paper denies.

2. **The limit is empty.** Fails if a frame can be exhibited that holds no structure not earning its cost and still does work — that is, if the criterion of well-formedness survives the removal of the purpose it is relative to.

3. **Underdetermination, not unknowability.** Fails if a discriminating observation between relation-first and relata-first can be specified from within any frame, in which case the question is settled rather than underdetermined; and fails in the other direction if the argument of Remark 3.1 can be shown not to presuppose its conclusion, in which case the stronger unknowability claim is recoverable.

References

Michael Esfeld. Quantum entanglement and a metaphysics of relations. *Studies in History and Philosophy of Modern Physics*, 35(4):601–617, 2004.

James Ladyman and Don Ross. *Every Thing Must Go: Metaphysics Naturalized.* Oxford University Press, Oxford, 2007.

Saunders Mac Lane. *Categories for the Working Mathematician.* Springer, New York, 1971.

Nāgārjuna. *The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way: Nāgārjuna's Mūlamadhyamakakārikā.* Translated by Jay L. Garfield. Oxford University Press, New York, 1995.

Thomas Nagel. *The View from Nowhere.* Oxford University Press, New York, 1986.

Bernard Williams. *Descartes: The Project of Pure Enquiry.* Penguin, Harmondsworth, 1978.